

Travel Diary

Brazil 2025



*Route: Cologne → Rome → Rio de Janeiro, day trips to Ilha Grande and Petrópolis
Wed November 12 – Sat November 22, 2025*

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Day 1 – Wednesday/Thursday, November 12/13 – Arrival & First Day on Copacabana

Via Rome: From Cologne via Rome to Rio: lounge in Fiumicino, then overnight across the Atlantic. Early in the morning we land at Galeão, Rio's international airport on Ilha do Governador, and join the immigration queue.





Leme and Copacabana: Our apartment is in Leme, the quieter eastern end of Copacabana below Morro do Leme. First stop: the beach. A coconut for a few reais, feet in the sand, the silhouette of the hills behind us.







"Coco gelado": ice-cold coconut, the beach staple.



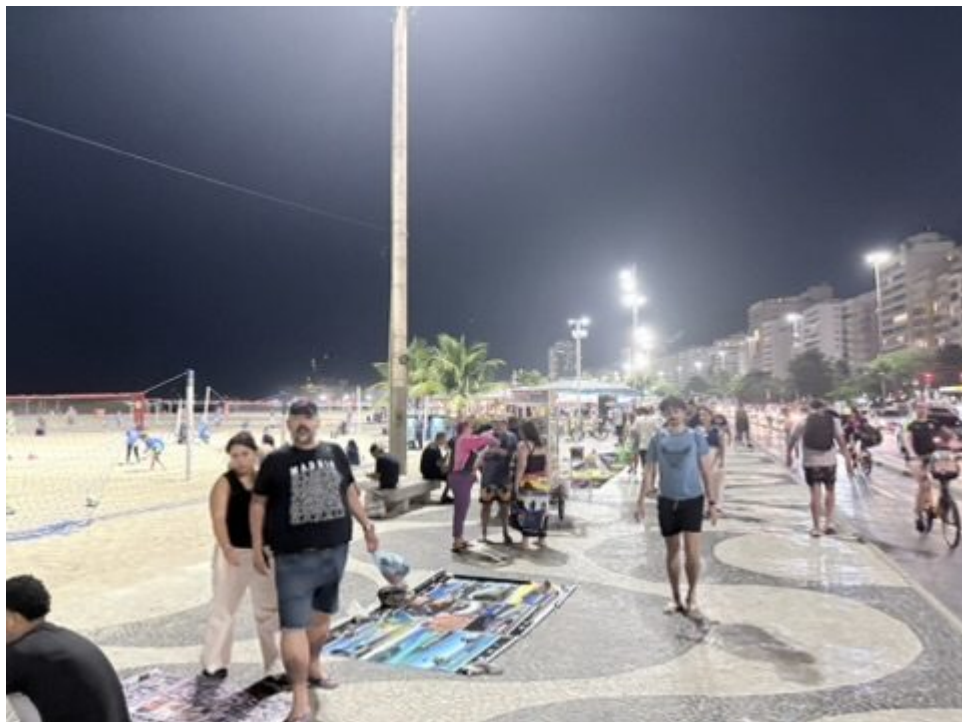








Havaianas, Brazil's most famous flip-flops, have been around since 1962 – here in every colour.





To finish, a fresh juice – Rio's sucos are in a class of their own.

Day 2 – Friday, November 14 – Beach, Lapa & the Selarón Steps

Beach afternoon: Umbrella, plastic chairs, a caipirinha vendor every few minutes. At the end of the beach locals play football and footvolley in front of Morro do Leme.





Lapa: In the evening to Lapa, the nightlife district. The white arches of the aqueduct, completed in 1750, once carried water into the city – since 1896 the tram to Santa Teresa has run across them. Dinner at a Peruvian place: ceviche and pisco.













Selarón Steps: From 1990 the Chilean artist Jorge Selarón turned the 215 steps between Lapa and Santa Teresa into a mosaic of more than 2,000 tiles from over 60 countries – many of them gifts from visitors. He worked on it until his death in 2013.





Rio's four big clubs on the tiles: Botafogo, Fluminense, Flamengo, Vasco.









To finish, an Eisenbahn – craft beer founded in 2002 in Blumenau, Brazil's most German city.

Day 3 – Saturday, November 15 – Copacabana & Fort Copacabana

Lunch in Leme: A corner botequim, football on TV, picanha on a wooden board. Saturday lunch in Rio.





On the Calçadão: On foot along Copacabana. The wave pattern of the Calçadão originally came from Portugal; landscape architect Roberto Burle Marx redesigned the promenade in 1970. Along the way: a giant yellow shoe installation on the beach, jersey vendors, lifeguard posts.







Fort Copacabana: At the southern end of Copacabana lies the fort, completed in 1914, with heavy Krupp guns in armoured turrets. In 1922 the revolt of the "18 of the Fort", young officers against the government, started here – the prelude to the tenentismo movement. Today an army museum with perhaps the best view back across the whole bay to Sugarloaf Mountain.











Carlos Drummond de Andrade: On the way back, Brazil's great poet Carlos Drummond de Andrade sits on a bench in bronze – since 2002, looking out to sea. On the backrest his line: "No mar estava escrita uma cidade" – a city was written in the sea.





Day 4 – Sunday/Monday, November 16/17 – Beach Days in Leme

Two quiet days: No plans, just beach: caipirinha in the sand, an espetinho from the grill vendor, and in the evening the sunset behind the Copacabana high-rises. On Monday, football at the botequim around the corner.











Day 5 – Tuesday, November 18 – Boat Trip to Ilha Grande

Along the Costa Verde: Early in the morning by tour bus from Rio down the Costa Verde, about two hours west. Coffee and coconut overlooking the bay of Mangaratiba.





Ilha Grande: By schooner out into the bay of Ilha Grande. The island is car-free and largely covered by Mata Atlântica, the Atlantic coastal rainforest. Until 1994 a notorious prison stood here, which long kept tourism away – today that is exactly its good fortune. Swimming stops in turquoise water, music and caipirinhas on board; on the way back dark clouds roll over the mountains.











Back in Rio: On the way back a giant Christmas tree lights up the roadside – Advent at 30 degrees. In Leme there is still plenty going on in the evening.



Day 6 – Wednesday, November 19 – Fla-Flu at the Maracanã

Beach before the big game: One more morning in Leme: red flag for dangerous currents, caipirinhas in the sand.





Before the match: In the afternoon to Maracanã. In an old botequim, Fluminense fans gather in maroon, green and white – and we are right in the middle. The closer to the stadium, the denser the crowd.

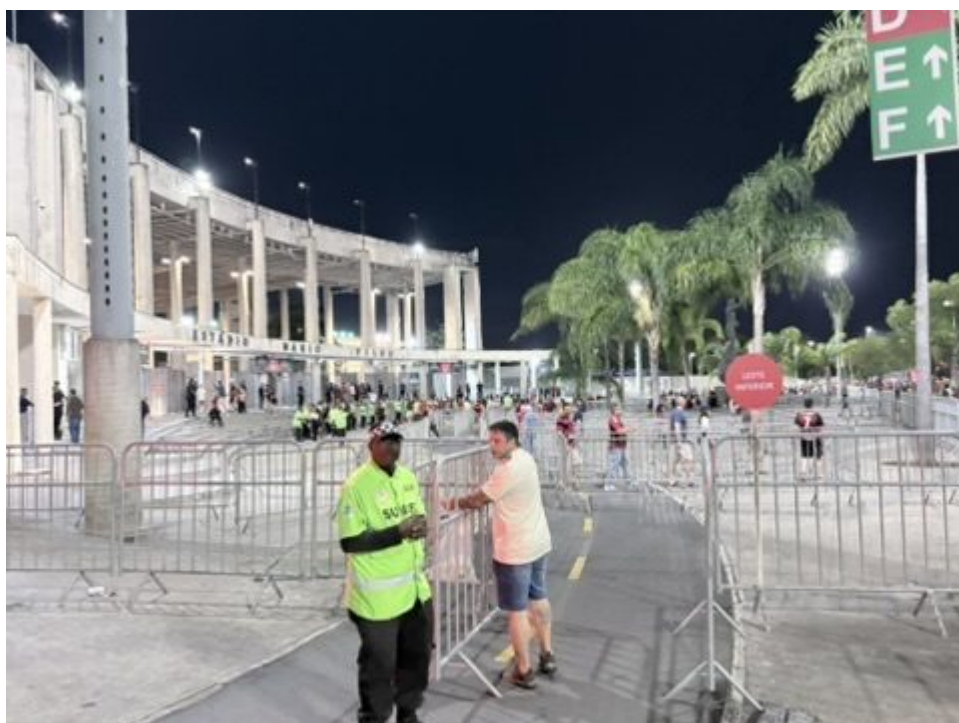








Fla-Flu at the Maracanã: The Maracanã was built for the 1950 World Cup; its official name is Estádio Jornalista Mário Filho, after the journalist who made the Fluminense vs Flamengo derby famous as the "Fla-Flu". The rivalry dates back to 1912. That night Fluminense win 2–1 – goals from Lucho Acosta (a stunner) and Serna. Flu's first Fla-Flu win of the year, and a setback for Flamengo in the title race.







Tip: Get tickets for the Fla-Flu early through the clubs' official member portals, and dress to match your section – maroon and green in the Flu end, red and black with Flamengo.

Day 7 – Thursday, November 20 – Tattoo, Centro & Porto Maravilha

A souvenir for life: The night after the derby was long – the Flu fans celebrated in front of their local bar until after midnight. At midday, a souvenir that lasts: Christ the Redeemer as a tattoo on the upper arm.









Centro on a holiday: November 20 is Dia da Consciência Negra, a nationwide holiday since 2024 in memory of Zumbi dos Palmares, leader of the largest quilombo community of escaped slaves. The city centre is packed, bands play on the streets of the old town. In the evening Candelária Church glows in the dusk.









Porto Maravilha: The old port district was completely redeveloped before the 2016 Olympics. Its landmark is Santiago Calatrava's Museum of Tomorrow (2015), whose white ribbed structure juts into the bay like a skeleton. Next to it, an old "Made in Germany" harbour crane recalls the past.







Day 8 – Friday, November 21 – Petrópolis, the Imperial City

Into the mountains: Early in the morning one last look at Ipanema, then up into the Serra dos Órgãos. Petrópolis lies a good 800 m up and was the summer residence of Brazil's Emperor Pedro II, who had the town founded in 1843; German immigrants settled here from 1845. A stop at Casa do Alemão, a roadside bakery selling bread and apple strudel since 1945. First stop is Palácio Quitandinha: opened in 1944 as South America's largest casino hotel – two years later gambling was banned in Brazil.







Imperial Museum: Pedro II's pink summer palace is now one of Brazil's most visited museums: furniture, paintings and the imperial crown set with 639 diamonds. Afterwards an Eisenbahn beer in the sun – the town is Brazil's beer capital anyway; the country's oldest brewery, Bohemia, was founded here in 1853.







Cathedral and Crystal Palace: The neo-Gothic cathedral of São Pedro de Alcântara was begun in 1884 and only completed in the 20th century; Emperor Pedro II and Empress Teresa Cristina rest in its funeral chapel. A few streets away stands the Palácio de Cristal, a glass palace prefabricated in France in 1884. And fittingly, to round things off: a beer garden.











Petrópolis was the adopted home of Alberto Santos-Dumont, whose 14-Bis took off in Paris in 1906 – for Brazilians the first true powered flight.

Last evening: Back on Copacabana: farewell dinner on Avenida Atlântica. On Saturday we fly back to Cologne via Rome.



